Accounts of discrimination during both the ceasefire period and the conflict were frequently used to explain motivations sparking women's involvement in or support for the conflict. This oppression is felt in both the public and the private sphere, and encompasses a range of interconnected areas including the labour market, education, health, justice, and infrastructure development. A feminist political economy analysis holds that these experiences are gendered and rooted in overarching social-economic and political inequalities. All female soldiers interviewed explained their participation in the army as contributing to the survival and struggle for Kachin nationhood on an equal footing to men. Most framed their involvement as related to nationalism and the national duty, and positioned women as protectors of their community. In this way, women's decisions to join or support the army are related to the insecurity that these women and their communities experience. As one KIA officer put it:

> The existence of KIO means that we can defend us against severe suppression from the government. Also, there are many parts in Kachin State where the government didn't take care of, but the KIO take care of the people and the land, also in the very remote areas, for education and health care. … Without the KIO the life of the people will be very difficult. KIO protects the people.[15]

GENDERED INSECURITY AND GENDERED RELATIONS IN IDP CAMPS

Within IDP camp communities, expectations of women to fulfil their gendered roles as caretakers of near and extended families are heightened. Women are expected to provide welfare for their families, but as resources are more limited, women's reproductive duties become strained. In addition to the responsibilities they hold for their families, women undertake unpaid labour in the camps, such as cleaning the camp compounds and building houses, which has a negative impact on their household income (Gender Equality Network 2013b, p. 11). These unpaid duties result in women having less time to participate in decision-making processes in the community and, as a consequence, women have not been able to influence decisions taken by camp committees in any substantial way. This is unfortunate, as the application of the male experience for designing the camps and social services available in them has had a negative impact on women's security.